Drew Johnston

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Education

Harvard University — **Cambridge, MA**
PhD, Economics — 2019-2024
AM, Economics — 2019-2022

Columbia University — **New York, NY**
BA, Computer Science and Economics — 2013-2017

Experience

OpenAI — **New York, NY**
Member of the Technical Staff (Data Scientist), Economic Research Team — 2026-

Meta — **New York, NY**
Postdoctoral Research Scientist, Computational Social Science — 2024-2026
Contractor, Central Applied Science — 2023-2024
Contractor, Core Data Science — 2018-2019, 2020-2023
Contractor, Feed Science — 2017-2018

Opportunity Insights — **Cambridge, MA**
Research Collaborator — 2024-
Graduate Research Assistant, Prof. Raj Chetty — 2021-2024

Working Papers

Economic Connectedness Around the World: Measurement, Determinants, and Effects
Forthcoming at *Nature*
with Theresa Kuchler, Ayush Kumar, Johannes Stroebel, Manas Kulkarni, and Michael Bailey
Press: La Vanguardia

The Shift to Agentic AI: Evidence from Codex
with David Holtz, Alex Martin Richmond, Christopher Ong, Prasanna Tambe, and Aaron Chatterji
Press: Axios

Social Ties and Residential Choice: Micro Evidence and Aggregate Implications
with Martin Koenen

Social Capital in the United Kingdom: Evidence from Six Billion Friendships
with Tom Harris, Shankar Iyer, Tom Rutter, Guanghua Chi, Patrick Lam, Lucy Makinson, Antonio S. Silva, Martin Wessel, Mei-Chen Liou, Yingcan Wang, Qamar Zaman, Mike Bailey
Press: Financial Times, The Economist, The Guardian (1), The Guardian (2), The Independent, The Times, The Standard
(Data) (Visualization)

Publications

The Social Connectedness Index: A Large-Scale Dataset of Social Ties across Geographic Locations
Data in Brief, 67(112905), June 2026
with Theresa Kuchler, Manas Kulkarni, Johannes Stroebel
(Data) (Visualization)

The Social Integration of International Migrants: Evidence from the Networks of Syrians in Germany
Journal of Political Economy, 134 (5), 1159-1209, April 2026
Best Poster at the *International Conference on Computational Social Science* (IC2S2 2022)
with Michael Bailey, Martin Koenen, Theresa Kuchler, Dominic Russel, Johannes Stroebel
(Appendix) (Data) (Slides) (Research Summary)

Cross-Gender Social Ties Around the World
American Economic Association Papers & Proceedings, 115, 132–38, May 2025.
with Michael Bailey, Theresa Kuchler, Ayush Kumar, Johannes Stroebel
Press: The Economist, SF Chronicle
(Data) (Appendix) (Code)

Measuring Global Migration Flows using Online Data
Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences, 122 (18) e2409418122, April 2025
with Guanghua Chi, Guy Abel, Eugenia Giraudy, Mike Bailey
Press: New York Times (1), New York Times (2)
(Data) (Appendix) (Code)

Social Networks Shape Beliefs and Behavior: Evidence from Social Distancing during the COVID-19 Pandemic
Journal of Political Economy Microeconomics, 2 (3), 463-494, August 2024
with Michael Bailey, Martin Koenen, Theresa Kuchler, Dominic Russel, Johannes Stroebel
Press: NBER Digest
(Appendix) (Code)

Social Capital I: Measurement and Associations with Economic Mobility
Nature, 608 (7921), 108-121. August 2022. (Cover Article)
with Raj Chetty, Matthew O. Jackson, Johannes Stroebel, Theresa Kuchler, Nathaniel Hendren, Robert Fluegge, Sara Gong, Federico Gonzalez, Armelle Grondin, Matthew Jacob, Martin Koenen, Eduardo Laguna-Muggenburg, Florian Mudekereza, Tom Rutter, Nicolaj Thor, Wilbur Townsend, Ruby Zhang, Mike Bailey, Pablo Barberá, Monica Bhole, Nils Wernerfelt
Press: NYT (1), NYT (2), The Economist, Washington Post, NPR, CBS, Axios, Brookings, El País, The Hill
(Social Capital Atlas) (Data) (Slides) (Summary) (Appendix)

Social Capital II: Determinants of Economic Connectedness
Nature, 608 (7921), 122-134. August 2022.
with Raj Chetty, Matthew O. Jackson, Johannes Stroebel, Theresa Kuchler, Nathaniel Hendren, Robert Fluegge, Sara Gong, Federico Gonzalez, Armelle Grondin, Matthew Jacob, Martin Koenen, Eduardo Laguna-Muggenburg, Florian Mudekereza, Tom Rutter, Nicolaj Thor, Wilbur Townsend, Ruby Zhang, Mike Bailey, Pablo Barberá, Monica Bhole, Nils Wernerfelt

Peer Effects in Product Adoption
American Economic Journal: Applied Economics, 14 (3), 488-526, July 2022
with Michael Bailey, Theresa Kuchler, Johannes Stroebel, Arlene Wong
Press: VoxEU, LSE Business Review, World Economic Forum
(Code) (Appendix)

Social Connectedness in Europe
International Conference on Social Informatics (SocInfo 2020), 1-14, October 2020
with Michael Bailey, Theresa Kuchler, Dominic Russel, Bogdan State, Johannes Stroebel
(Data) (Code) (Appendix) (Facebook Research Blog)

Policy Reports

The War in Ukraine and the Potential of Facebook's Social Connectedness Index to Anticipate Human Displacement
UN International Organization for Migration: Migration Research Series, No. 73, April 2023
with Umberto Minora, Martina Belmonte, Claudia Bosco, Stefano Iacus, Eugenia Giraudy, Francesco Sermi

Conference & Seminar Presentations

2025	International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2)	(SweCSS)
	NSF Conference on Network Science and Economics	(Stanford)
	American Economic Association Meeting	(San Francisco)
2024	Digital Technologies and Sustainable Development Workshop	(Oxford)
	Barcelona Summer Forum (Migration)	(BSE)
2023	NSF Conference on Network Science and Economics	(Virginia Tech)
	European Networks Conference	(Central European University)
	Urban Economics Association European Meeting	(Bocconi)
	Summer School on the Economics of Migration	(UC Davis & Alianza MX)
2022	International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2)	(UChicago)
	Stanford Institute for Theoretical Economics	(Stanford)
	Urban Economics Association Annual Meeting	(World Bank)

2021	Networks 2021 (Sunbelt & NetSci joint meeting)	(Virtual)
	Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting	(Houston)
2020	Facebook Computational Social Science Seminar	(Virtual)

Invited Lectures, Panels & Public Speaking

2026	EdLinks—AI & the Future of Work Panel	(SJF Ventures)
	Development Data Partnership Panel	(World Bank)
	United Nations Behavioral Science Week—Panel on AI & Human Agency	(Virtual)
2025	Sciences Po (Transdisciplinary Approaches to Inequality)	(Virtual)
2024	Urban Libraries Council Annual Meeting	(Washington, D.C.)
2023	Boston College Economics Honor Society	(Boston College)

Professional Activities

Refereeing: Nature, the Quarterly Journal of Economics ($\times 3$), the Review of Economics and Statistics, the Economic Journal, the Journal of Urban Economics ($\times 2$), the American Sociological Review, PNAS Nexus, Management Science, and the Cambridge Journal of Regions, Economy and Society

Program Committee: FAccT '23 (ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency)

Other

Member, Brooklyn Community Board 9 2025-
Member, Social Capital Lab
Affiliated Researcher, Laboratorio de Oportunidades (Spain)
Affiliate, Harvard Institute for Quantitative Social Science
2x NCAA Team Fencing Champion